

IT's in Us



Maulik Jasubhai

In a lecture on motion and gravity, our bespectacled physics lecturer once taught us about Escape Velocity—the exact speed required for an object to “escape” earth’s gravitational pull so that it does not fall back. This velocity—around 25,000 miles an hour—is one of the most important constants in rocket science.

I remembered this figure because India is now on the threshold of a different kind of escape velocity, a constant that will either put India on the growth curve, or push it down a spiral of technological oblivion.

The next 12 months, therefore, could well define the future of technology penetration and usage in India.

For long, India’s march on the technology battlefield has been held back, not by its brain power, but by its sheer lack of collective will. It does show up, but in spurts—like when Nasscom lobbies to prevent outsourcing from being banned in the US, or MAIT influences the government to bring down duties and taxes to encourage hardware sales growth.

To be sure, Nasscom and MAIT will only be minor catalysts in our technological advancement—it will be people like us who will drive the engine.

A caveat, though—is technology usage the only measurement of growth?

Former Andhra Pradesh chief minister Chandrababu Naidu, may have known Bill Gates on first name basis, but he did not know what the person on the street wants. Even as Hyderabad bid for a Formula 1 racetrack—which incidentally uses so much technology that the engineers at MIT would be proud—Naidu lost track of what real development means. Here is a simple thing that Naidu forgot—technology is only a tool for development, not development by itself.

Award-winning journalist Thomas Friedman, in his perceptive column for the *New York Times*, recently wrote where India is truly shining—in a village near Bangalore where armyman-turned-software scientist-turned-social worker Dr Abraham George is bringing about a quiet revolution by building a school called Shanti Bhavan for underprivileged children who get to work on PCs every day, and build a life through education and self-respect.

When Friedman met the students there, he played a typing match on the PC keyboard against an eight-year-old girl. He lost.

India’s future as a technological powerhouse, you’d realise when you visit places such as Shanti Bhavan, is not rooted in how many outsourcing contracts we win, or how many million cellphone connections we have, or how much percentage of the population can access the Internet.

It is rooted in us. And unless we collectively achieve the escape velocity my physics teacher so passionately talked about, we will be grounded. For life.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Maulik Jasubhai'.

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Publisher and Executive Director, Jasubhai Digital Media